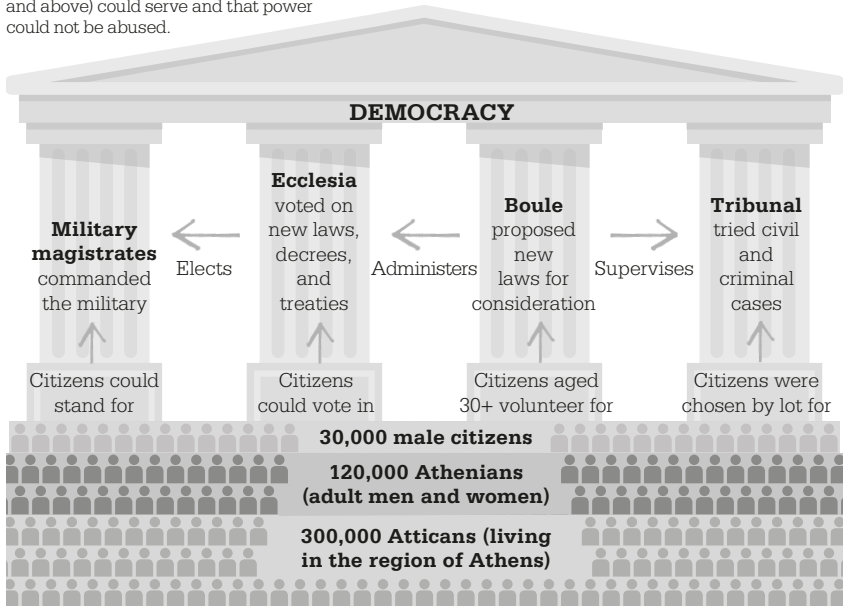


18 ATHENIAN DEMOCRACY

The Athenian constitution relied on a careful separation of powers. This was essential to make the practical operation of direct democracy possible. It also ensured that all citizens (men aged 20 and above) could serve and that power could not be abused.



positions rather than basing the choice on heredity. In addition, he restructured the Boule—a council of 500, which drew up legislation and proposed laws to the assembly of voters (*Ecclesia*). In 501 BCE, command of the military was transferred to popularly elected generals (*strategoi*).

In 462 BCE, Ephialtes became leader of the democratic movement in Athens and, together with his deputy Pericles, he dismantled the Areopagus council, transferring the majority of its powers to the Boule, the Ecclesia, and the citizen courts. Ephialtes was assassinated in 461 BCE and Pericles took over the political leadership, becoming one of the most influential rulers in the history of ancient Greece.

A perfect democracy?

Athens now had a genuine direct democracy, but many people were not allowed to participate in the system as they were not considered true citizens. Political rights were restricted to adult male Athenians; women,

foreigners, and enslaved people were excluded. In the 4th century BCE, out of the 300,000-strong population of Attica—the region of Greece controlled by Athens—just 30,000 men comprised the voting population. In theory, men became voting citizens at age 18, but as they were generally liable for two years of military service they were not enrolled on the rosters of the council until they turned 20, and did not come into their full political rights until the age of 30.

During the “Pentekontaetia”—the decades between Greek victory in the Persian War (479 BCE) and the start of the Peloponnesian War (431 BCE)—Athens reached the height of its glory. In 447 BCE, Pericles appropriated the treasury of the Delian League (the anti-Persian confederation that had become a vessel for Athenian hegemony) to build a magnificent temple (the Parthenon) on the rocky hill known as the Acropolis. Citizenship of Athens was highly coveted, and in 451 BCE Pericles passed a law restricting it to men whose parents were both Athenians.